The Voluntary Exit

Philosophy and the Question of Suicide: A Survey of Arguments from Antiquity to Contemporary Ethics

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1. The Problem Stated

There is a sentence that has followed the discipline of philosophy since 1942, when Albert Camus opened *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* with the claim that there is only one truly serious philosophical problem, and that it is suicide. Judging whether life is worth the trouble of being lived, he wrote, is answering the fundamental question of philosophy. Everything else—whether the world has three dimensions, whether the mind has nine or twelve categories—comes afterwards.

The claim is deliberately provocative, but it is not frivolous. Most philosophical questions can be deferred. This one cannot, because it concerns the condition under which any other question can be asked at all. A theory of knowledge, a theory of justice, a theory of meaning: each presupposes a subject who continues to exist and who finds the continuation tolerable enough to keep asking.

What follows is not an argument for or against the act. It is a survey of how the Western tradition, and briefly the Eastern one, has reasoned about it: where the prohibitions came from, which of them survive scrutiny, and what remains genuinely unresolved. The reader should keep one distinction in view throughout. Philosophy has almost always discussed suicide as a *question about reasons*—whether a life can be rationally ended, and by whom that judgment may be made. It has rarely discussed it as a description of a person in pain. The gap between those two things is where most of the difficulty lives.

2. Antiquity: The Reasonable Exit

Greek and Roman thought did not treat self-killing as a unified moral category. It was, in the main, a question of circumstance. Plato, in the *Phaedo*, has Socrates argue that human beings are possessions of the gods, stationed at a post that must not be abandoned without orders; the prohibition is thus theological rather than self-regarding. In the *Laws*, the same worry appears in legal dress: the suicide is to be buried without honour, in an unmarked grave.

Aristotle was less systematic but no warmer. In the *Nicomachean Ethics* he denies that suicide is an act of courage, since the courageous man dies for something fine, whereas the suicide dies to escape poverty, desire, or pain—which is a kind of cowardice. Elsewhere he treats it as an injury to the city, because the citizen belongs in part to the community that raised him.

The Stoics moved in the opposite direction. For them the question was not whether one may exit, but when the exit is *reasonable*. Zeno and Cleanthes defended the wise man's right to depart when circumstance obstructed the life according to nature. Seneca, in the seventieth letter to Lucilius, is explicit: the wise man lives as long as he ought, not as long as he can, and the door stands open. What matters is the logos of the decision—the account one can give. Cato of Utica became the exemplar, reading the *Phaedo* before dying rather than submit to Caesar, and the Roman imagination made of that a picture of liberty rather than despair.

Epicurus offers a different register. Death, he argued, is nothing to us, since where death is, we are not. That is usually read as consolation rather than counsel. Yet the tradition produced Hegesias of Cyrene, whose lectures were said to be so persuasive in favour of dying that Ptolemy forbade him to teach—the ancient world's clearest example of a philosophy that had to be suppressed not because it was false but because it worked.

> *The wise man will live as long as he ought, not as long as he can. — Seneca, Epistulae Morales 70*

3. The Christian Reversal

Augustine supplied the argument that would govern a thousand years of European practice. The commandment *thou shalt not kill*, he insisted in *The City of God*, is not qualified by the words *thy neighbour*; it covers the self as well. To kill oneself is to kill a human being, and no exception is written in. The reasoning is compressed but its consequence is total: the act becomes a species of murder.

Aquinas systematised it in the *Summa Theologiae* with three arguments that are still worth separating, because they fail or succeed independently. First, suicide contradicts the natural inclination to self-preservation, and therefore violates the natural law inscribed in every creature. Second, it injures the community, to which each person owes the service of belonging. Third, and decisively for Aquinas, life is a gift held in trust, and dominion over it belongs to God alone. A man who kills himself usurps a jurisdiction that is not his.

The first argument is the weakest as stated, since natural inclinations are descriptive facts about what creatures tend to do, not by themselves normative constraints on what they may do. The third is the strongest, but only if its premise is granted—and that premise is precisely what modern secular ethics declines to grant. The second argument has proven the most durable, and it survives in secular form whenever someone argues that a death is a harm to those left behind.

4. Hume: The Case Against the Prohibition

David Hume's essay *On Suicide* was written around 1755 and published posthumously in 1777, and it remains the sharpest single attack on the traditional position. Hume grants the theological premise for the sake of argument and then shows that it proves too much. If God's providence governs all events, then every death is equally an interference with it; the man who builds a house to keep out the weather is already meddling. There is no principled line between the ordinary exercise of human agency and the final one.

Against the charge of social duty, Hume answers that withdrawal from society is not itself a crime—the hermit and the monk do it—and that when a life has become a burden to its possessor and a charge upon others, the release may be a benefit on both sides. Against the charge of self-injury, he invokes what is essentially a property argument: of all our possessions, our life is the most intimately our own, and it would be strange if we might alienate a house or a field but not the tenancy of our own existence.

The essay was suppressed in Hume's lifetime and remained difficult to obtain for two centuries. Its importance is structural rather than rhetorical: it established that the prohibition is not self-evident, that its premises require defence, and that a secular ethics would have to find grounds for it other than divine ownership.

5. Kant: The Duty to Oneself

Kant accepted Hume's challenge and tried to meet it without theology. In the *Groundwork*, the suicide appears in the examples of the first formulation of the categorical imperative: a man weary of life asks whether self-destruction is consistent with the idea of humanity as an end in itself. Kant's answer is that a maxim to destroy the very subject of morality cannot be universalised without contradiction, because the same self-love that motivates the act would, as a law of nature, destroy the condition of any law-governed action whatsoever.

The argument has been criticised on at least two fronts. The contradiction Kant identifies is not obviously a contradiction at all; a maxim to end one's life when it has become unbearable can be conceived as a general law without logical incoherence, and the universalisation test was not designed to filter out self-regarding maxims of this kind. More seriously, Kant's conclusion depends on treating the rational agent as a thing of absolute worth that must be preserved—which is a substantive moral claim about the value of continued existence, not a formal consequence of the categorical imperative.

Kant's personal authority on the question should also be noted, quietly: he held that the duty to preserve oneself extends to refusing acts that degrade or instrumentalise the body, and used examples—selling a tooth, mutilating oneself—that modern readers find disproportionate. The intuition he was defending, that persons are not merely things to be used, is separable from the conclusions he drew from it.

6. Schopenhauer and Nietzsche: Two Answers to Suffering

Schopenhauer gives the question its metaphysical frame. If the world is the objectification of a blind will that can never be satisfied, then suffering is not an accident of circumstance but the texture of existence, and the interesting question becomes what attitude to take toward it. His verdict on suicide is unexpectedly conservative. The suicide, he argues, wills the cessation of suffering but in doing so affirms the will to live—he wants the world on different terms, not the abolition of wanting. The genuine denial of the will is the ascetic's renunciation, which continues to live while ceasing to will.

Nietzsche is often misread here. He despises what he calls the preachers of death, those who counsel renunciation while secretly resenting life, and he distrusts suicide as a form of revenge against oneself. But he also insists on dying at the right time, and his praise of a free death—one chosen in the fullness of a life rather than in its exhaustion—is a demand for sovereignty over the ending, not a prohibition on it. The difference between Schopenhauer and Nietzsche is the difference between renouncing the will and mastering it.

7. Camus and the Absurd

Camus's response to his own opening question is not the one readers expect. The absurd, for him, arises from the collision between the human demand for meaning and the world's silence; it is neither in the world nor in the mind, but in their relation. Suicide, he argues, does not resolve that collision—it abolishes one of its terms. The leap of faith does the same thing from the other side, by inventing a meaning that was never there.

What remains is revolt: to live without consolation, lucidly, and to find sufficiency in the struggle itself. Sisyphus, rolling his stone, is to be imagined happy—not because the task is meaningful, but because he has refused both the escape of suicide and the escape of false hope. Whatever one makes of the argument, its form is instructive: Camus treats suicide as an *answer* to the absurd, and rejects it not on moral grounds but on logical ones, as answering the wrong question.

8. Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky, and Despair

Kierkegaard's *Sickness Unto Death* diagnoses the condition rather than the act. Despair, he argues, is not wanting to be oneself, or wanting to be a self one is not; it is a misrelation of the self to the power that constituted it. Suicide appears there as a false cure, an attempt to escape the self rather than to become it. The despairing person does not want to die, in the ordinary sense; he wants to be rid of a self he cannot bear, which is a different wish and cannot be satisfied by death.

Dostoevsky dramatises the same insight in Kirillov, in *Demons*, who reasons that if God does not exist then man is god, and that the highest proof of that freedom is to kill oneself. The construction is deliberately monstrous: a metaphysics of liberation arriving at an act of destruction, and Dostoevsky means the reader to see the whole chain of inference as a symptom rather than an

argument.

9. The Contemporary Debate: Rationality

Twentieth-century analytic ethics largely abandoned the theological frame and asked a narrower question: can suicide be rational? Margaret Pabst Battin's work is the most sustained treatment. She separates the claim that suicide is immoral from the claim that it is irrational, and argues that the standard proofs of irrationality fail. The act is not irrational merely because it is irreversible—many decisions are irreversible—nor because the agent is in pain, since pain may be a truthful perception of circumstance rather than a distortion of judgment.

Against this, three objections carry weight. The first is evidential: the great majority of those who attempt suicide and survive do not go on to die by suicide, and many report relief at having been interrupted. If the desire is frequently transient, the irreversible act is frequently a mistake. The second is epistemic: judgments about one's own future are systematically unreliable under depression, in the specific sense that the prediction 'this will never improve' is a symptom rather than an assessment. The third concerns adaptive preference: prolonged suffering can reshape what a person wants, and it is not obvious that a want formed under such conditions should be treated as authoritative.

R. B. Brandt and Thomas Szasz pressed the opposing case, Szasz most sharply, on grounds of self-ownership: if the body is the person's, the burden of proof falls on those who would restrain him. The debate has since migrated into the assisted-dying literature, where the same arguments reappear in a narrower setting—competence, voluntariness, and the difficulty of distinguishing a settled request from a treatable crisis. That difficulty, rather than any metaphysical disagreement, is what most modern legal systems actually respond to.

10. Outside the West

The Abrahamic framing of suicide as sin is not universal. In Buddhism the act is not a transgression against a creator but an act with karmic consequence, and the tradition's emphasis falls on the state of mind at death rather than the deed itself; the canonical position discourages it while recognising that the underlying suffering is the real problem. Confucian ethics situates the person in a web of obligation, and the *Classic of Filial Piety* treats the body as received from one's parents, so that self-injury is a debt unpaid. Hindu and Jain traditions contain regulated practices of self-willed death under strict conditions—the Jain *sallekhana* being the most discussed, and the subject of a contested Indian court ruling in 2015 that weighed religious liberty against the risk of coercion.

What the comparison shows is that the prohibition is not a deliverance of reason as such. It is a conclusion drawn from premises about ownership, duty, and the sacred—premises that differ across traditions and that a secular ethics must either reconstruct or abandon.

11. What Remains Open

Three questions survive the survey, and none of them has been settled.

Ownership. Does a person hold his life as property, as Hume suggests, or as a trust, as Aquinas holds? The answer determines whether the act is a liberty or a trespass, and the argument turns on whether the self is prior to its relations or constituted by them.

Authority. Who may judge that a life is no longer worth living—the person living it, or anyone else? The epistemic problem is severe in both directions: the outsider cannot feel the pain, and the insider cannot see past it. Every legal regime answers this question by choosing whom to trust, and every choice is a wager.

Reversibility. The act is the only decision that forecloses the possibility of revising it. Whether that fact is a reason against it, or merely a feature of it, depends on how much weight one gives to the possibility that one is wrong. Most of the practical ethics of the subject—the waiting periods, the assessments, the hesitation of clinicians—is an attempt to price that possibility.

Camus's question, then, is not answered here, and the survey suggests it will not be answered by argument alone. What philosophy can do is clarify the terms on which the question is asked, expose the premises that ordinarily go unexamined, and resist the temptation to convert a genuinely hard problem into a comforting certainty in either direction.

Further Reading

Aquinas, Thomas. *Summa Theologiae*, II-II, q. 64, a. 5.

Aristotle. *Nicomachean Ethics*, III.7 and V.11.

Augustine. *The City of God*, Book I.

Battin, Margaret Pabst. *Ethical Issues in Suicide*. Prentice Hall, 1996.

Battin, Margaret Pabst. *The Ethics of Suicide: Historical Sources*. Oxford University Press, 2015.

Brandt, Richard B. 'The Morality and Rationality of Suicide.' In *Moral Problems*, 1970.

Camus, Albert. *The Myth of Sisyphus*. Gallimard, 1942.

Cioran, E. M. *The Trouble with Being Born*. 1973.

Hume, David. 'On Suicide.' 1777.

Kant, Immanuel. *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*. 1785.

Kierkegaard, Soren. *The Sickness Unto Death*. 1849.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, 'On the Preachers of Death' and 'On Free Death.'

Plato. *Phaedo* 61c-62c; *Laws* IX.

Schopenhauer, Arthur. *The World as Will and Representation*, vol. 1, section 69.

Seneca. *Epistulae Morales*, 70.

Szasz, Thomas. *Fatal Freedom: The Ethics and Politics of Suicide*. 1999.

Wittgenstein, Ludwig. *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, 6.4311.

A note on reading. The arguments surveyed above are addressed to questions of justification, not to persons in distress. Philosophical analysis of a practice is not an assessment of any particular life, and the literature is nearly unanimous on one empirical point: most suicidal crises are temporary, and most people who survive them are glad to have done so. Readers who recognise themselves in these pages are better served by a conversation than by a conclusion.